



Elm chair
c. 1850

This Ming-style elmwood chair has a shaped crest rail and curved backrest with openwork cartouches above a beaded apron.

scene of
birds

decorative
panel

painted
doors



flowers

fruit



Jade brush holder
c. 18th century

The detail of this jade brush holder contains the figure of Taoist philosopher Lao Tzu. The ancient Taoist practices were popular in the Ming period but fell out of favor with Qing rulers.

Soapstone Lohan
1600–1799

This statue shows a Lohan, a human who achieved enlightenment through meditation on the teaching of Buddha. Buddhism flourished during the Qing period.



Elm cabinet
c. 1860

The doors of this black lacquered elm cabinet of rectangular outline are painted with a colorful decoration that includes birds and flowering trees.

THE QING DYNASTY

OBJECTS FROM THE EMPIRE THAT RULED CHINA FOR MORE THAN TWO CENTURIES

The Qing dynasty was established after the last Ming emperor was overthrown in 1644. Rule was instituted by Manchu chieftains, and the Qing period of rule lasted until 1911. It was a time in which China witnessed a tripling of its population to around 450 million.

Although the Manchus were seen as outsiders by the Chinese, they maintained their rule for so long by continuing to use the existing form of government from the Ming dynasty (1368–1644). This continuity spilled over into the arts and crafts as well, and much of the work produced in the Qing years was heavily influenced by Ming designs, especially porcelain.



Flask
1736–95

Supported on a spreading circular foot, this flask has a short, contracted neck and right-angle handles. The sides have bands of exotic blooms.

cinnabar
lacquer

copper-red
underglazing

head is made
of chalcedony



Ax head
19th century

Made from chalcedony, this translucent green and red ax head has a flat, curved cutting edge. Carved in relief is a Taotie mask and sleeping silkworms.

dragon



Belt hook
19th century

This jade belt hook has a Taoist design, shaped as two dragons and a bat laid on the outside, a phoenix on one side, and a silkworm pattern on the reverse.

Covered box
1736–95

The top of this peach-shaped covered box (the fruit is a symbol of long life) shows a *chun* (spring) character enclosing, in the center, Shou Lao, the god of longevity, with a dragon on either side.

hook is
carved
from jade

intricate
carving

